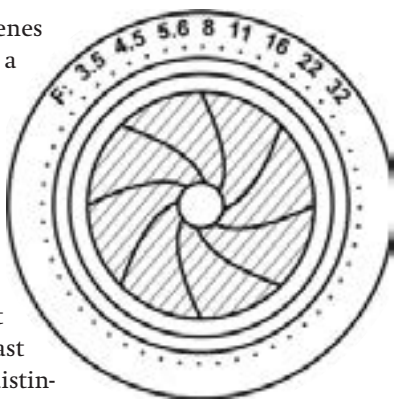


same goes for high-speed scenes in low light. Variable F-stop is a luxury not usually available in consumer-level camcorders. However, prices are constantly dropping and you may want to consider going in for a camcorder with variable F-stops. A critical reason for this is that CCDs have limited contrast range. They find it hard to distinguish between the lightest and darkest pixels that are more than five F-stops apart. Outside this range, light areas appear as white or bleached, and dark areas look murky or black.



1.2.8. Automatic Vs. Manual Exposure Control

The exposure determines the brightness and crispness of your video. There are four elements that go into controlling the exposure settings: focus, shutter speed, aperture, and colour balance. While the first three have already been explained, colour balance or white balance as it is more popularly known is a feature where the camcorder automatically adjusts the colours in the scene to make it “truer” to life-like colours than what the CCD actually “sees”.

Higher-end models may allow you to control each of the four settings individually, though you will need plenty of practice before you can figure out the best combinations that work for any given lighting and movement scenario. Most consumer models have one or two fixed-exposure settings, or will have pre-programmed settings for common shooting situations like Sports, Landscape, Low Light, Sunny, etc. This can be helpful if you are uncomfortable with adjusting each of the exposure control elements individually.

The other factor to keep in mind with manual control, as explained in §1.1.1 and §1.1.2, is ease of button and functionality